Tabletop 3: The Support Call

Student Investigation Packet | Competing explanations, coordinated response, business continuity, and recovery criteria

Fictional training exercise. All records are simplified and use one exercise day, HarborMart local time UTC-04:00. No real tools or external contacts are required. Do not open domains or attempt actions against real systems.

Your assignment

Maya Brooks in accounts payable reports following instructions from someone claiming to be IT support. Assess evidence, recommend a coordinated response, and define what would need verification before normal use resumes.

Information is intentionally incomplete. Missing fields are not proof of malicious activity. Request specific information from the moderator, explain the question it answers, and record what remains unknown. Additional information will arrive during the exercise. Some uncertainty is deliberately unresolved.

Authority and coordination

The incident lead coordinates response and may approve temporary restrictions on an individual account or workstation. IT administrators implement changes. Disrupting shared production services requires leadership and system-owner coordination. Legal/privacy coordinates external notification assessment; communications manages approved external messaging. External engagement follows designated relationship owners. These are fictional HarborMart exercise rules.

T3-A | Employee statement

Maya: "Someone called saying my invoice application needed repair. They sent a support-page link. I downloaded the repair file. Later the cursor moved when I was not touching the mouse. I closed the window and called the help desk." This is a witness account, not independent verification of every event.

T3-B | Browser extract

ID / time	Observation
B1 10:03	Visit to support.harbormart-help.example (fictional reserved example domain)
B2 10:05	Download of HarborMart_Repair.zip started
B3 10:06	Download completed

T3-C | Simplified endpoint/session extract

ID / time	Observation
C1 10:09	Approved remote-support application started
C2 10:10	Session identifier created; remote operator unavailable in extract
C3 10:16	Application closed

T3-D | Operations

Workstation HM-AP-014. Support software was installed before this event. No help-desk ticket authorizes the session. A payment deadline is approaching and a spare workstation is available. Payment-system and mailbox audit records are not included. Download execution is not established.

Team discussion

1. Build a short timeline and distinguish observations from interpretations.

2. What are at least two explanations to test?

3. What immediate action balances risk with the payment deadline?

4. Which additional evidence and stakeholders are needed?

5. What conditions must be checked before recovery or normal use?

Team Decision Record

Team: _____ Recorder: _____

Investigative question

_____

_____

Supported observations: cite record IDs

_____

_____

Current explanation and one alternative

_____

_____

Missing information: request, purpose, and owner

_____

_____

Initial recommendation: action, rationale, priority, and approval

_____

_____

Update received: what changed?

_____

_____

Revised recommendation and stakeholder communications

_____

_____

Reassessment trigger / remaining uncertainty

_____

_____

Prepare a 60-second update: What we know; what we do not know; what we recommend; who needs to act; what happens next.